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Section Title(S)

DIAGNOSIS AND CURES FOR THE EVIL EYE ATTACK • PRECAUTIONS AGAINST EVIL EYE ATTACK

Another precaution taken by the Amhara peasant against the possibility of attack is to be silent and guarded. When one expresses his emotions too freely and becomes too outgoing with others, he places himself in a position of vulnerability to the evil eye. This disposition is fairly generalized. When one is seen laughing and joking freely with others it is usually with close and trusted friends and relatives. At most other times the peasant presents a facade of stolidity and silence. In this way one does not attract the attention of an envious *buda*, who may resent persons enjoying themselves while he is not invited to share in the mirth. The custom of hiding one's face behind the large soft cloak, concealing especially the mouth and the nose, is one common way to avoid the penetration of the evil eye.

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If a person succumbs to the attack of the evil eye, the family of the deceased may intercede and prevent the *buda* from wresting the corpse from its grave. A member of the family must watch the grave for forty days and forty nights (some say twelve days and twelve nights) after the body has been interred, allowing sufficient time to elapse so that the body will be adequately decomposed and thereby deprive the *buda* of a body to possess. If the grave is watched the *buda* will not come. In this way the family saves their relative from seven years of slavery.

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DIAGNOSIS AND CURES FOR THE EVIL EYE ATTACK

Diagnosis of the symptoms and subsequent treatment may be carried out in one of four ways. In the first method, if the family is poor and they know a *däbtärä* of the local church, they may take the patient to him. For a modest fee, he performs a rite over holy water, praying and pronouncing words in the ancient language of Giiz used in the Christian religious ceremonies. The patient then drinks the holy water and breathes in the smoke of a burning

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root. The *dābtärä* may find the diagnostic answer in his magic star book, while the holy water and inhaled smoke may effect a cure.

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A second alternative is to bring the patient to a wizard, one who has powers gained through agents of the devil, to communicate with the *zar* ■285 spirits and to effect cures for many kinds of illness. First, a silver bracelet is placed on the patient's left wrist. The wizard then goes into a trance, seeking possession by a devil who may reveal the appropriate cure for the illness. In seeking out the attacker, a very hot fire is made in the hearth and a piece of metal, a sickle or knife blade, is put into the flames and heated until glowing. The hot metal is applied to the patient's face, making a small pattern of burns. As the wounds heal, the scars will become transferred onto the face of the attacker in the same place and with the same pattern. The family must then seek out the guilty party.

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